

Dvar Torah Outline — Parashat Ki Tisa (Theme): “עם קשי עורף” as a Critique that Reveals Jewish Greatness

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman explores the Torah’s description of the Jewish people as “עם קשי עורף” (a stiff-necked people), showing—following the Maharal—that this is not merely a criticism but also a window into a core Jewish strength. He connects this trait to the tension in Pirkei Avot between **holy brazenness** (needed for avodat Hashem) and **corrupt brazenness** (which leads a person astray). Rabbi Shulman frames Jewish “stubbornness” as an expression of spiritual steadfastness that has sustained Jewish commitment across millennia of exile, even while acknowledging how the same trait can fuel national failures like the Golden Calf.

I. “עם קשי עורף”: criticism that hints at inner greatness

A. The Torah’s descriptor

- Rabbi Shulman opens with the Jewish people being called “עם קשי עורף”—a “stiff-necked people.”
- It is said as a criticism, yet Rabbi Shulman notes (based on the **Maharal**) that it can also emerge from a deep greatness.

B. The core question

- How can the same personality trait be:
 - spiritually heroic, and
 - spiritually destructive?
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II. Pirkei Avot: brazenness praised and brazenness condemned (0:30)

A. A seemingly contradictory Mishnah

- Rabbi Shulman points to a Mishnah in **Pirkei Avot, perek 5**:
 - Encouragement: **a person should be brazen like a leopard** to do the will of “his Father in Heaven.”
 - Warning from the same tanna:
 - **”עז פנים לביהנום”** (brazen-faced people go to Gehinnom)
 - **”ובושת פנים לבן עדן”** (those with a sense of shame go to Gan Eden)

B. The tension

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes: it’s the same character trait—boldness/brazenness.
 - The difference is not whether one has stubbornness, but **where it is aimed** and **what values fuel it**.
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III. Maharal: Jewish brazenness comes from belief, not convenience (2:00)

A. Defining brazenness as “unbending commitment”

- Rabbi Shulman explains (citing the **Maharal**, particularly in **Netzach Yisrael**) that Jewish brazenness is rooted in being **unbending because of real belief**.
- When a person does something because it is:
 - convenient,
 - easy,
 - pleasurable, they will drop it when it stops being so.

B. Contrast with the nations of the world

- Rabbi Shulman frames “the nations” as more likely to follow what is easy or pleasurable—and to abandon commitments when circumstances change.
- The Jewish people, by contrast, tend to continue because they **believe**.

C. Example of “sticking to one’s identity” even when irrational

- Rabbi Shulman gives a contemporary illustration (party loyalty) to show how a person can cling to an identity even “in spite of everything.”
 - Point: that same stubbornness can play out:
 - negatively (misplaced loyalty), or
 - positively (loyalty to Torah).
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IV. Exile, scoffing, and how spiritual stubbornness preserves Torah life (3:30)

A. The historical pressure to conform

- Rabbi Shulman describes Jewish endurance over **millennia** (contrasted with America’s 250-year history).
- Jews were “scoffed at” for mitzvot, for serving Hashem, and for maintaining ancient practices.

B. Why scoffing matters

- Scoffing is portrayed as a powerful social tool to force change.
- Rabbi Shulman illustrates how even small ridicule can make people discard behavior quickly.

C. The answer: a unique Jewish resilience

- Jews maintained Torah and mitzvot through:
 - pressure,
 - temptation,
 - seduction,
 - scoffing,
 - abuse.
 - Rabbi Shulman identifies the sustaining engine as:
 - brazenness,
 - idealism,
 - determinism,
 - unwavering commitment.
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V. Stiff-neckedness as a sign of spiritual (not physical) identity (5:01)

A. Physical reality changes under external force

- Rabbi Shulman uses a physics metaphor (Newton): an object changes direction when acted upon by an external force—like a billiard ball.

B. Spiritual truth does not bend

- Rabbi Shulman contrasts this with spiritual/intellectual reality:
 - Truth remains true regardless of pressure (e.g., “one plus one equals two” stays true no matter how much someone denies it).

C. Applying the metaphor to Am Yisrael

- Jewish stubbornness signals that Jewish identity is:
 - **spiritual**,
 - **transcendent**,
 - not merely reactive to trends.
 - Even if the identity was formed in a “twisted” or unhealthy way, the underlying capacity for resilience remains.
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VI. Reframing the critique: “קשי עורף” as praise—if directed correctly (6:30)

A. The double edge

- Rabbi Shulman reiterates:
 - stiff-neckedness is destructive when moving in the wrong direction,
 - but it is powerful and even praiseworthy when aligned with avodat Hashem.

B. Not being “fair-weather fans”

- Rabbi Shulman contrasts Jewish steadfastness with “flapping around depending on what’s trending.”
 - He calls steadfastness a “great praise”: it reflects spiritual depth.
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VII. Tisha B'Av: the same trait behind failure and survival (7:00)

A. The destruction connected to stiff-neckedness

- Rabbi Shulman notes that coming out of **Tisha B'Av**, we recognize national disasters tied to stubbornness:
 - the Golden Calf,
 - the sin of the spies,
 - and related failures.

B. The survival also connected to stiff-neckedness

- Yet Rabbi Shulman stresses the paradox:
 - that very same trait enabled Jewish continuity through 2,000 years of exile.
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VIII. Hopeful closing: mourning transformed into joy (8:00)

- Rabbi Shulman concludes with a prayerful hope:
 - that **Tisha B'Av** should be "נתהפך... ליום טוב"—transformed into a festival in the coming year.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman reframes "עם קשי עורף" as a critique that also points to a uniquely Jewish spiritual power: steadfast commitment.
- Pirkei Avot shows the trait's dual potential: brazenness can be holy (for mitzvot) or corrupt (leading to Gehinnom).
- Following the Maharal, Jewish stubbornness is rooted in deep belief rather than convenience, explaining Jewish resilience across millennia of exile.
- The same stiff-necked quality can fuel national sin (Golden Calf, spies) yet also preserves Jewish loyalty to Hashem—and is part of the hope that Tisha B'Av will ultimately transform into joy.